# James W.A. Strachan

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## Biography

**Postdoctoral fellow** — Mohamed VI Polytechnic University, Rabat MA
*Faculty of Governance, Economic & Social Sciences* — *2026*

**Humboldt Fellow** / **Postdoc** — University Medical Center Hamburg-Eppendorf, Hamburg DE
*Department of Neurology* — *2023-2025*

**MINDED Research Fellow** — Italian Institute of Technology, Genoa IT
*Cognition, Motion, and Neuroscience Unit* — *2020 - 2022*

**Postdoctoral Researcher** — Central European University, Budapest HU
*Department of Cognitive Science* — *2016 - 2020*

**PhD in Psychology** — University of York, York UK
*Professor Steve Tipper (thesis supervisor)* — *2013 - 2017*

**Thesis**: Incidental learning of trust from identity-contingent gaze cues: boundaries, extensions and applications

**Award date**: July 14th 2017

**MSc in Cognitive Neuroscience** — University of York
*Professor Andy Young (thesis supervisor)* — *2012 - 2013*

**Thesis**: Involvement of the superior temporal sulcus in decoding social signals from faces

**BSc in Psychology** — University of York
*2009 - 2012*

## Funding and Fellowships

**Humboldt Research Fellowship for Experienced Researchers** — 2023-2024
*Individual research fellowship by the Alexander von Humboldt Foundation* — *€57,060*

**MINDED MSCA-COFUND Fellowship** — 2020-2022
*Research fellowship awarded as part of MSCA-COFUND Action*

**BA/Leverhulme Small Research Grants [SRG1920-100325; Co-PI]** — 2020
*Learning who to trust: How do we re-affiliate after social exclusion?* — *£9,929*

**Wellcome Trust: Centre for Chronic Diseases and Disorders [Co-investigator]** — 2016
*Influencing Facial Trustworthiness in Sleep* — *£6,988*

## Journal Articles

**Strachan, J.**, Pansardi, O., Scaliti, E., Celotto, M., Saxena, K., Yi, C., Manzi, F., Rufo, A., Manzi, G., Graziano, M., Panzeri, S., Becchio, C., (2026). "GPT-4o reads the mind in the eyes". In: *Computers in Human Behaviour* 181, p. 108992.

**Strachan, J.**, Albergo, D., Borghini, G., Pansardi, O., Scaliti, E., Gupta, S., Saxena, K., Rufo, A., Panzeri, S., Manzi, G., Graziano, M., Becchio, C., (2024). "Testing Theory of Mind in Large Language Models and Humans". In: *Nature Human Behaviour* 8, pp. 1285–1295.

Charbonneau, M., Curioni, A., McEllin, L., **Strachan, J.,** (2023). "Flexible cultural learning through action coordination". In: *Perspectives on Psychological Science* 19 (1), pp. 201–222.

Charbonneau, M., **Strachan, J.**, Winters, J., (2023). "The problem with solutions: Comment on "Blind alleys and fruitful pathways in the comparative study of cultural cognition" by Andrew Whiten". In: *Physics of Life Reviews* 44, pp. 61–63.

Charbonneau, M., **Strachan, J.,** (2022). "From Copying to Coordination: An Alternative Framework for Understanding Cultural Learning Mechanisms". In: *Journal of Cognition and Culture* 22, pp. 451–466.

**Strachan, J.**, Curioni, A., Constable, M., Knoblich, G., Charbonneau, M., (2021). "Evaluating the relative contributions of copying and reconstruction processes in cultural transmission episodes". In: *PLOS One* 16 (9), e0256901.

**Strachan, J.**, Török, G., (2020). "Efficiency is prioritised over fairness when distributing joint actions". In: *Acta Psychologica* 210, p. 103158.

**Strachan, J.**, Constable, M., Knoblich, G., (2020). "It Goes With The Territory: Ownership Across Spatial Boundaries". In: *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception and Performance* 46 (8), pp. 789–797.

**Strachan, J.**, Guttesen, A., Smith, A., Gaskell, M., Tipper, S., Cairney, S., (2020). "Investigating the formation and consolidation of incidentally learned trust". In: *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Learning, Memory and Cognition* 46 (4), pp. 684–698.

**Strachan, J.**, Sebanz, N., Knoblich, G., (2019). "The role of emotion in the dyad inversion effect". In: *PLOS One* 14 (7), e0219185.

**Strachan, J.**, Kirkham, A., Manssuer, L., Over, H., Tipper, S., (2017). "Incidental learning of trust from eye-gaze: Effects of race and facial trustworthiness". In: *Visual Cognition* 25 (7-8), pp. 802–814.

**Strachan, J.**, Tipper, S., (2017). "Examining the durability of incidentally learned trust from gaze cues". In: *Quarterly Journal of Experimental Psychology* 70.10, pp. 2060–2075.

**Strachan, J.**, Kirkham, A., Manssuer, L., Tipper, S., (2016). "Incidental learning of trust: Examining the role of emotion and visuomotor fluency". In: *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Learning, Memory and Cognition* 42, pp. 1759–1773.

Flack, T., Andrews, T., Hymers, M., Al-Mosaiwi, M., Marsden, S., **Strachan, J.**, Trakulpipat, C., Wang, L., Wu, T., Young, A., (2015). "Responses in the right posterior superior temporal sulcus show a feature-based response to facial expression". In: *Cortex* 69, pp. 14–23.

## Book Chapters

**Strachan, J.**, Begus, K., (2026). "Theory of Mind". In: *On Human Nature: Biology, Psychology, Ethics, Politics, and Religion*. Ed. by M. Tibayrenc. 2nd ed. Routledge. Available for preorder; expected publication December 2026. ISBN: 9780443336911.

**Strachan, J.**, Curioni, A., McEllin, L., (2024). "Flexible Social Learning of Technical Skills: The Case of Action Coordination". In: *The Evolution of Techniques: Rigidity and Flexibility in Use, Transmission, and Innovation*. Ed. by M. Charbonneau. The Vienna Series in Theoretical Biology, MIT Press. Chap. 6. ISBN: 9780262378390.

**Strachan, J.**, Knoblich, G., Sebanz, N., (2020). "Skill and Expertise in Joint Action". In: *The Routledge Handbook of Philosophy of Skill and Expertise*. Ed. by C. Pavese and E. Fridland. Chap. 29.

## Preprints and Working Manuscripts

**Strachan, J.**, Mayo, R., Sebanz, N., (under review). *When thinking about your partner gets in the way: Coordination failures in joint decision-making*. Preprint available from https://osf.io/szeuw/.

Zhao, Q., Pansardi, O., **Strachan, J.**, Manzi, G., Borghini, G., Manzi, F., Rufo, A., Vignemont F. M. G., Panzeri, S., Becchio, C., (submitted). *Inverting the Turing Test reveals dissociations between encoding, readout and meta-readout*. Manuscript submitted to journal.

## AWARDS

**YuFund, York Alumni Association** £200
*Grant for public engagement event Psych!York* *2016*

**Postgraduate Community Fund, York Graduate Student Association (GSA)** £574
*Grant for public engagement event Psych!York* *2016*

**International Meeting of the Psychonomic Society, Granada, Spain**
*Accommodation Award* *2016*

**UK National 3-Minute Thesis Competition** [URL]
*National Semi-Finalist* *2015*

## SUPERVISION & TEACHING

*Note: All teaching has been delivered in English*

**Experimental Methods: Design and Data collection** 2026
*UM6P, Rabat, Morocco*

- **Degree programme:** Behavioral Sciences for Public Policy (2nd year undergraduate)
- **Number of students:** 23 students
- **Role:** Module organiser
- **Teaching form:** Lectures, lab sessions
- **Responsibilities:** Syllabus creation; Teaching delivery; Examinations; Marking
- **Evaluation:** 4.08 / 5

**Guest Lecturer** November 2019
*Eötvös Loránd University (ELTE), Budapest, Hungary*

- **Course:** Introduction to Cognitive Science (1 semester)
- **Degree programme:** MSc in Computational and Cognitive Neuroscience
- **Number of students:** 40
- **Role:** Guest lecturer
- **Teaching form:** Classroom lecturing
- **Responsibilities:** Creating and delivering an individual lecture on joint attention and communicative gaze; Coordinating with course coordinator on topic and presentation

**Guest Lecturer** 2018-2019
*Budapest University of Technology and Economics (BME), Budapest, Hungary*

- **Course:** Introduction to Social Cognition (1 semester)
- **Degree programme:** MSc in Computational and Cognitive Neuroscience
- **Number of students:** 20
- **Role:** Guest lecturer
- **Teaching form:** Classroom lecturing
- **Responsibilities:** Creating and delivering an individual lecture on joint attention; Coordinating with course coordinator on topic and presentation

**Graduate Teaching Assistant - Tutorial Lead** 2013-2016
*University of York, York, UK*

- **Degree programme:** Psychology BSc (2 semesters per academic year, 9 1-hour slots per semester
- **Topics covered:** Cognitive Psychology; Social Psychology; Developmental Psychology; Perception; Attention; Cognitive Neuroscience; Research Methods; Statistics
- **Number of students:** 9 groups of c.15 students
- **Educational level:** Undergraduate

* **Role:** Teaching assistant
* **Teaching form:** Seminar groups; Paper discussions; Small-group classroom teaching
* **Responsibilities:** Leading a seminar group; Leading discussion; Small-group teaching; Seminar development on social cognition and perception; Coordination with course leader to develop learning objectives in line with course content; Training other teaching assistants on seminar content; Refining and revising seminar content

**Graduate Teaching Assistant - Examination** 2013-2016
*University of York, York, UK*

* **Degree programme:** Psychology BSc (2 semesters per academic year)
* **Number of students:** 30-40
* **Educational level:** Undergraduate
* **Role:** Teaching assistant
* **Teaching form:** Essay and report marking; Student feedback
* **Responsibilities:** Marking and evaluating student reports; Coordinating with course leader; Providing feedback to course leader on general trends in student performance for course refinement

**Mentorship** 2013-2022
*University of York; CEU; IIT; UKE; UM6P*

* **Number of Students:** 7 undergraduate students (University of York); 3 postgraduate interns (CEU; IIT; UKE); 1 Masters student (CEU/University of Vienna); 1 undergraduate research assistant (UM6P)
* **Responsibilities:** Mentorship of undergraduate and Masters student projects; Training in research methodology, data analysis, scientific writing, and presentations

## Research Methods & Technical Skills

**Methods**: Motion capture (Vicon); Experimental design; Open Science

**Programming**: R; MATLAB; Python; Javascript

**Languages**: English (native); Italian (B2); German (B1); French (B1) *CEFR levels are approximate*

## Professional Activities

### External roles

**INDEEP AI** [Link]
*Advisor, Cognitive Science*

**Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception & Performance** [Link]
*Consulting Editor* *Since 2020*

### Ad-hoc reviewer

*Acta Psychologica; Attention, Perception, and Psychophysics; British Journal of Psychology; Cognition; Cognition and Emotion; Cognitive Science; Communications Psychology; Experimental Psychology; Frontiers in Psychology; iScience; Journal of Archaeological Science; Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception and Performance; Journal of Experimental Social Psychology; Journal of Nonverbal Behaviour; Nature Communications; PLOS One; PNAS; PNAS Nexus; Proceedings of the Royal Society A; Proceedings of the Royal Society B; Psychological Science; Psychonomic Bulletin & Review; Quarterly Journal of Experimental Psychology; Science Advances; Scientific Reports; Visual Cognition*

## Society Memberships

**Marie Curie Alumni Association (MCAA)**
*Member* *Since 2022*

**Cultural Evolution Society**
*Member* *Since 2026*

## Department Roles

**Undergraduate entrance examinations** Jury member
*FGSES, UM6P* *2026*

## Impact and Engagement

**Psych!York** [URL]
*Organising committee for all-day public engagement event staffed by early-career researchers* *2016*

**Science and Technology Network Launch** [Video]
*Invited talk at Royal Institution, London* *2016*

**PUBlic Seminar** [URL]
*Public engagement seminar. Won Audience Favourite prize* *2016*

**Shine School Outreach Program** [Program]
*Outreach lecture to Yorkshire schools: Introduction to Psychology* *2016*

**Science is Vital: York Chapter** [National Campaign URL]
*Organised and hosted Science Is Vital event as part of national campaign* *2015*

**YorNight Research Café** [URL]
*European Researchers Night* *2015*

**York Graduate Research School Launch**
*Invited talk at the University of York* *2015*

## Conference Presentations

**Strachan, J.**, Pansardi, O., Scaliti, E., Celotto, M., Saxena, K., Yi, C., Manzi, F., Rufo, A., Manzi, G., Graziano, M., Panzeri, S., Becchio, C., (July 2025). "GPT4o reads the mind in the eyes". Talk accepted for the tenth Joint Action Meeting (JAM X) 2025, Turin, Italy.

**Strachan, J.**, Becchio, C., (Mar. 2024). "Kinematic signatures of pedagogical communication". Symposium talk delivered at the 66th Tagung experimentell arbeitender Psycholog:innen (TeaP; Conference of Experimental Psychologists).

**Strachan, J.**, Albergo, D., Borghini, G., Pansardi, O., Scaliti, E., Rufo, A., Manzi, G., Graziano, M., Becchio, C., (Mar. 2024). "Testing Theory of Mind in GPT Models and Humans". Poster delivered at the 66th Tagung experimentell arbeitender Psycholog:innen (TeaP; Conference of Experimental Psychologists).

**Strachan, J.**, Becchio, C., (July 2023). "Building demonstrations from scratch: Understanding pedagogical communication in teaching interactions". Talk delivered at ninth Joint Action Meeting (JAM 9) 2023, Budapest, Hungary.

**Strachan, J.**, Török, G., (Mar. 2022). "Do people choose to be efficient or fair when allocating tasks in a joint action?" Symposium talk at the 64th Tagung experimentell arbeitender Psycholog:innen (TeaP; Conference of Experimental Psychologists).

**Strachan, J.**, Charbonneau, M., Curioni, A., Constable, M., Knoblich, G., (Aug. 2020). "A methodology for distinguishing copying and reconstruction in cultural transmission episodes". Paper accepted for the 42nd Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, online July 29-August 1, 2020.

**Strachan, J.**, Charbonneau, M., Curioni, A., Constable, M., Sperber, D., Knoblich, G., (July 2019). "Active cultural transmission: Exploring the role of pedagogy in transmission and learning". Talk delivered at eighth Joint Action Meeting (JAM VIII) 2019, Genova, Italy.

**Strachan, J.**, Török, G., Sebanz, N., (May 2019). "Investigating the role of fairness in task distribution". Poster presented at the Dubrovnik Conference on Cognitive Science (DuCog), 2019, Dubrovnik, Croatia.

**Strachan, J.**, Mayo, R., Sebanz, N., (Mar. 2019). "The role of generalised distrust in coordinated decision-making". Symposium talk delivered at the International Convention of Psychological Science (ICPS) 2019, Paris.

**Strachan, J.**, Török, G., Sebanz, N., (Mar. 2019). "When Being Efficient Is Unfair: Investigating the Role of Fairness in Task Distribution". Poster presentated at the International Convention of Psychological Science (ICPS) 2019, Paris.

**Strachan, J.**, Constable, M., Knoblich, G., (Oct. 2018). "Ownership Effects Across Territory Boundaries." Poster presented at DisSelf conference and workshop in Porto, Portugal.

**Strachan, J.**, Torok, G., Sebanz, N., (Sept. 2018). "To Be Fair... Investigating the drive towards fairness in task distribution". Poster presented at Social Cognition in Robots and Humans workshop in Hamburg, Germany.

**Strachan, J.**, Mayo, R., Sebanz, N., (Aug. 2018). "Think For Yourself: When trying to coordinate leads to less efficient coordination strategies than acting individually." Symposium talk given at meeting of the British Psychological Society Cognitive Section at Liverpool Hope University.

**Strachan, J.**, Knoblich, G., Sebanz, N., (Feb. 2018). "Perceiving dyads as perceptual units". Poster presented at the inaugural Interactive Eye Gaze Workshop at UCL, London.

**Strachan, J.**, Knoblich, G., Sebanz, N., (July 2017). "Investigating the effect of joint speech on discrimination of truth". Poster presented at the 8th Joint Action Meeting at Queen Mary University, London.

**Strachan, J.**, Tipper, S., (Aug. 2016). "Incidental learning of trust does not result in distorted memory for the physical features of faces". Poster presented at the 39th European Conference on Visual Perception in Barcelona.

**Strachan, J.**, Tipper, S., (May 2016). "Effects of Real-World Social Group Status on Incidental Learning of Trust." Poster presented at International Meeting of the Psychonomic Society, Granada.

**Strachan, J.**, Tipper, S., (Jan. 2016). "Investigating the Durability of Incidentally Learned Trustworthiness Impressions". Talk presented at the January meeting of the Experimental Psychology Society, UCL, London.

**Strachan, J.** (Nov. 2015). "Learning to trust: Background learning of social information". Invited seminar, Wentworth College, University of York.

**Strachan, J.**, Tipper, S., (July 2015). "Incidentally learning of traits from gaze cues generalises to judgements of unrelated stimuli". Poster presented at Social Cognition Workshop, Bangor University.

**Strachan, J.**, Tipper, S., (May 2015). "Using scalar ratings to track changes in apparent trustworthiness induced by helpful and misleading gaze cues". Poster presented at Vision Sciences Society Annual Conference, St. Pete Beach, FL.